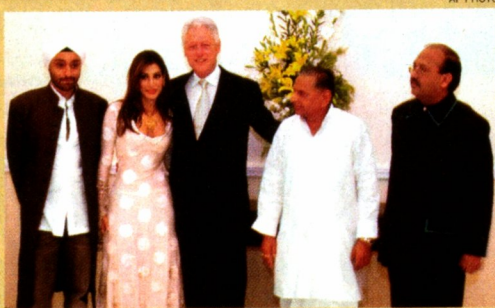


CIRCLE OF FRIENDS



POWER AND GLORY: Amar Singh counts as close friends, ex-president Clinton (above) and industrialists like Anil Ambani (below)



STRONG BONDS: Amar Singh's friendship with the Bachchans was perhaps the strongest and the most enduring. When either was down and troubled, the other was around to lend a shoulder.

He combines politics with wealth and

GLAMOUR. HE WINS UNLIKELY FRIENDS

in the highest circles of urban India.

Sonia, made the alliance easier. Now Singh has to prove that his power is real, not an illusion.

He knows, and it's that constant awareness that makes him the most animated politician in the capital. "He was always at home managing, even stage-managing at times, crises. We have seen this trait since his school days," says his classmate and SP state unit President Vijay Upadhyaya. Today he is perhaps the only leader of a regional party with a national image, even though the image is not necessarily flattering. He is the brand ambassador of a political wrestler called Mulayam and works overtime to build a ring larger than Uttar Pradesh for the boss. Mulayam is the provincial vote and Amar is the national voice—as the *dharti putra* Yadav looks after the badland fiefs, the networker influences some of the most important drawing rooms of urban India and wins unlikely friends in the highest circles. (The trinity of Amar, Amitabh, Anil is a force you can't ignore.) Envious party colleagues may fume: "*Humari party mein log pahale tel lagate the aur jab se Amar Singh aayen hai, yeh log tel ki jagah deo lagate hain*" (earlier our leaders used oil on their body and after the arrival of Amar Singh they use deodorant). Singh doesn't care. For him, party doesn't mean always political.

In the age of cohabitation, he is perhaps the best—and the wildest—practitioner of realpolitik in an India where ideology is negotiable when the highest bidder is in the fray. For such a politician,

morality is a vocational hazard and ethics is a fancy word for dreamers—not for doers. What matters is power, and this man knows how to use it to extend his domain. And in his case power multiplies when he combines politics with wealth and glamour. Every political crisis is an opportunity for him to increase his market value. July 22 provides such a moment. The immediate challenge, though, is numerical. How is he going to get the numbers? As a seasoned artiste of break-and-build, he has fixed a target of securing the support of 12 additional MPs. He has to ensure that Mayawati does not succeed in taking away his MPs while doing his best to get about half a dozen from her party. He is confident of winning Ajit Singh who has three MPs and who contested as an ally of SP. He also has hopes from Independents from other states. From Karnataka, he expects a favour from the old friend, Deve Gowda. A confident Amar Singh tells INDIA TODAY, the UPA will get 290 votes.

If he succeeds, he'll consecrate himself as the new kingmaker. If he fails, he'll see that his loss is lesser than his new friends', certainly in Uttar Pradesh. Then there is that bitter truth of trust: The Congress may ride piggyback on him to victory in Parliament, but the party has a bad history of using and then dumping the ally. Amar Singh is not easily perishable. Those who are in his orbit should know, and his new suitors are only getting to know him, number by number.

with bureau reports